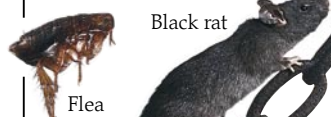


Plague and poetry



Black rat

Flea

DIRTY RATS
People did not know it, but the plague was carried by blood-sucking fleas that lived on the black rats that swarmed through the city's dirty streets. Between 1592 and 1593, plague-carrying fleas led to the deaths of almost 12,000 Londoners.

OUTBREAKS OF A TERRIBLE disease called the plague were common in Elizabethan London. Nobody knew how the plague spread, but when there was an outbreak it seemed wise to avoid crowded places. By law, the city's playhouses could not open if more than 30 people had died in one week. Between 1592 and 1594, the plague was so bad that the playhouses had to stay closed for just over two years. The companies of actors left London to tour the countryside in order to make a living. There was no demand for Shakespeare to write new plays, so he turned to poetry.



The Earl of Southampton, painted by Nicholas Hilliard in about 1594

*"Rich men trust not in wealth,
Gold cannot buy you health:
Physic himself must fade. All
things to end are made, The
plague full swift goes by; I am
sick, I must die: Lord have
mercy on us."*

THOMAS NASHE

Summer's Last Will and Testament, 1592

SERIOUS WRITING

Henry Wriothesley, the Earl of Southampton, was Shakespeare's patron. While the playhouses were shut, Shakespeare wrote two long poems, *Venus and Adonis* and *The Rape of Lucrece*, and dedicated them to his patron. This was Shakespeare's bid to be taken seriously as a writer. Playwrights were looked down on, but poets were respected, especially if they had aristocratic patrons.



Lavender

Sage

Marjoram

Rosemary

Elizabethan golden pomander set with precious stones

Cautery

Each section held a different herb

SMELLY CITY

Many Londoners tried to protect themselves from the plague by carrying pomanders (decorative containers holding sweet-smelling herbs). London was dirty and smelly, and all kinds of garbage was left to rot in the streets. People thought that there was a link between the plague and the bad air in the city.

BAD MEDICINE

Doctors during Shakespeare's time sometimes used a white-hot metal rod called a cautery to burst the swellings, called buboes, that appeared in the armpits and groins of plague victims. This treatment was extremely painful and did little to help the patient to recover.